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piece. The few sessions before the pain surfaced had been good. The doctors said that surgery is the only way to cure this.

"Had I gone for surgery, I would have been out of that World Championship and the remaining year. Plus, the recovery time for the Olympics would have been limited. Even in the off-season, we did not have enough time to recover and come back for the Olympics," Neeraj said.

With the Olympics now out of the way, and him having the distinction of being India's first back-to-back Olympic medallist in athletics, Neeraj can focus on his journey to return to full fitness.

He does not have to look far to see athletes who have recovered and only gone one better after undergoing surgery. His close friend and rival, Arshad, who won gold at the Paris Games with an Olympic

record throw, underwent surgical intervention to treat his knee in 2023. Anderson Peters, too, underwent an operation for a knee ailment in 2019 and is now back among the upper echelons.

The Pakistani national record holder had sought the tutelage of Liebenberg to get back in shape with minor adjustments to his technique.

"Arshad had some knee problems and then also some elbow problems. He was here for five weeks. We were doing technique work and rehabilitation, making the whole body strong. It's about strengthening the whole body. Then, it's also about working around the injury.

"We were working with a physiotherapist and in consultation with Dr. Bajwa, his physician, who would always explain exactly what he'd like to do. We would just work around the injury," Liebenberg said.

Liebenberg added that with Dr. Klaus Bartonietz and Ishan Marwaha, Neeraj has a team that could make him fire on all cylinders seamlessly.

"I consider myself lucky to be with such a team. I have been with him [Klaus] since 2019. We have a good relationship; we plan things together. After Paris, we mainly discussed the lack of throwing due to the injury. He also cannot work too much on this if I do not throw," Neeraj said.

If this version of Neeraj, the one that depends largely on his upper body strength, can nearly crack 90 metres, then surely the one at the peak of his powers can sail past the mark with ease.

"Bohot kuch hai andar, karenge agar shareer ne saath diya," Neeraj quipped after relinquishing his Olympic crown. He knows this, and the world might get a glimpse of it soon.